A Resource-Efficient Hardware Accelerator for Lossless Image Compression Based on the Walsh–Hadamard Transform

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***Abstract*—Placeholder abstract. To be written for the final article (max. 250 words).**

***Index Terms*—Discrete transforms, Image coding, Data compression, Field programmable gate arrays, Hardware acceleration, High level synthesis**

I. Introduction

[Sección a redactar por el compañero asignado. Ver guía en los comentarios.]

II. Background and Related Work

The Walsh–Hadamard transform (WHT) decomposes a signal into Walsh basis functions whose values are restricted to ± 1. For a signal of 2^n samples the transform is a multiplication by the $2^n \times 2^n$ Hadamard matrix, and since its entries are ± 1 it can be evaluated with additions and subtractions alone. The fast WHT (FWHT) lowers the arithmetic cost from $O(N^2)$ to $O(N \log_2 N)$ through Cooley–Tukey-style factorizations [1], and its parallel-pipeline hardware implementations follow processor structures first developed for the fast Fourier transform [14].

Exact reconstruction is what keeps the WHT from being lossless. Its inverse normalizes by the transform size N, a division that integer arithmetic cannot represent exactly, so a direct WHT loses information over a round trip through the transform and its inverse. Integer, reversible formulations remove this limitation. The unified lossless WHT (ULWHT) recovers the original data exactly while lowering the per-coefficient entropy of natural images [2], and a lossless two-dimensional WHT has also been derived [3]. For hardware there is a caveat: the one-dimensional lossless WHT still contains multiplications, and making it fully multiplier-free needs a more elaborate construction [3].

Two closely related solutions provide reproducible results with public code, and between them they cover both sides of the problem. One is an FPGA WHT accelerator: a configurable parallel-pipeline FWHT produced by high-level synthesis, with its HLS source openly released [1]. The other is a parallel lossless compressor for raw Bayer images on an FPGA-based high-speed camera that sustains $40.1\,$Gbit/s at $320\,$MHz on a Zynq UltraScale+ device, using adaptive Golomb–Rice coding and a public reference implementation [5]. One supplies the transform, the other a low-latency lossless pipeline; bringing the two together is the open problem.

Five further works address parts of the problem. In hardware, a multiplier-free WHT running at $162\,$MHz takes the place of the Photo Core Transform in JPEG XR [4], an FPGA JPEG 2000 accelerator performs on-board lossless compression [6], and an ANS-based coder reduces the complexity of JPEG-LS [7]. The integer lossless WHT formulations achieve bit-exact compression but stop at the algorithmic level, with no hardware realization [2], [3]. Earlier WHT processors based on distributed arithmetic [11], the sequency-ordered complex Hadamard transform [12], and a radix-2 Walsh–Hadamard–Fourier pipeline [13] were built for high throughput and small area, drawing on the low complexity of the ± 1 kernel [8].

The WHT also appears outside compression, in image watermarking [15], ultrasonic coded excitation [9], and the simulation of quantum algorithms [10]. Across this literature we found no hardware accelerator from the past decade that performs lossless, WHT-based compression of high-frame-rate image streams. The reproducible accelerators cover either the transform [1] or the lossless coding [5], and the lossless integer WHT has stayed at the algorithmic level [2], [3]. Closing this gap is the aim of the present work.

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